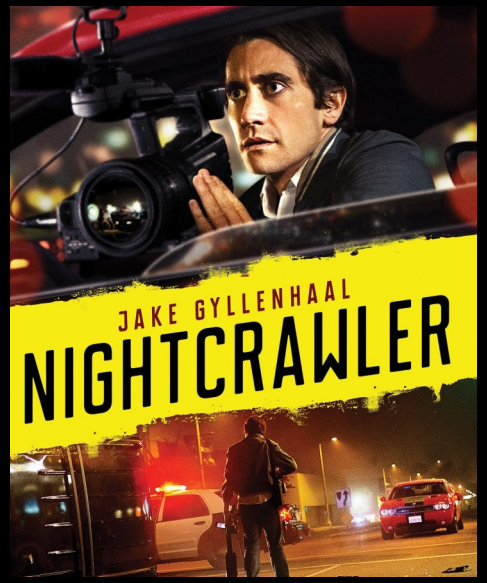
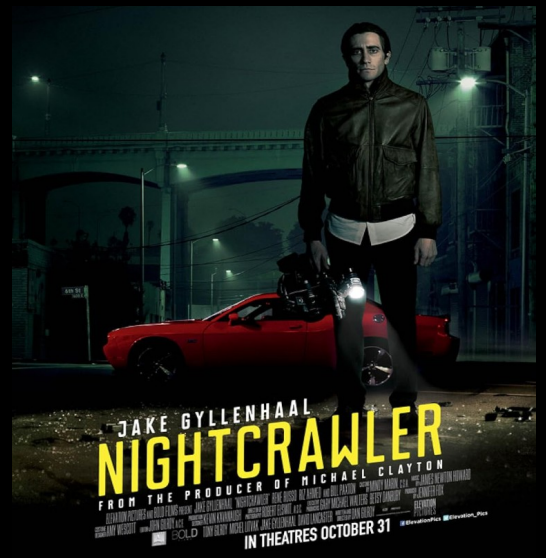


Journalists in Popular Culture: Nightcrawler and Spotlight



The Films

Nightcrawler (2014)

Directed and written by Dan Gilroy.

A purely fictional neo-noir thriller and social satire.

Received an Oscar nomination for Best Original Screenplay

7.8 /10 stars on IMDB
4/5 stars on Rotten Tomatoes.

Spotlight (2015)

Directed and written by Tom McCarthy and Josh Singer.

Won two Oscars – Best Picture and Best Original Screenplay

8.1/10 stars on IMDB

4.3/5 stars on Rotten Tomatoes

Review
Nightcrawler review – Gyllenhaal hits career high
★★★★☆
A creepy, gaunt Jake Gyllenhaal plays a sociopath with a scanner and a video camera in Dan Gilroy's gripping LA drama

ENTERTAINMENT MOVIES
Review: *Spotlight* Is an Emotional Tour de Force

How are the journalists represented?

Nightcrawler

Most of the scenes featuring Lou and other journalists are shot in the dark surroundings, connoting their almost criminal nature.

Nina, the KWLA news director, is motivated by her channel's ratings rather than the journalistic obligation to serve the society by telling important stories.

Spotlight

All of the reporters are represented as real heroes who want to share the stories of those who experienced sexual abuse at the hands of Catholic priests and so protect the society.

“I am here because I care. We’re not going away.” (Sacha Pfeiffer)

What are the journalists' attitudes to their work? How is the newsroom shown?

- Nightcrawler
- We see Journalists driven more by profit and competition rather than truth
- So the boundaries of ethics are tested and even ignored at times
- We see Nina (news director) even reject colleague's attempt to highlight the illegitimate nature of obtaining intimate footage
- Snowball effect with how Jake Gyllenhaal's character responds to his footage selling
- Complete disregard for humanity and lack of empathy toward vulnerable groups - 'if it bleeds it leads'
- Movie is a caricature of sorts that depicts the appalling lengths that are gone to, to 'get the story'

- Spotlight
- In contrast, Spotlight presents a much more patient and methodical approach to researching the stories, and makes a wider commentary on truth, justice and moral responsibility.
- We see more time spent researching and more empathy towards victims.
- Journalism is presented as more of a public service, and the reporters use their job to hold powerful organisations accountable.

How important is the role of “The Story”?

Sets out a cinematic message to their audiences.

Over the course of 2002, the Spotlight team published close to 600 stories about the scandal.

Nightcrawler

(negative) Cinematic representation of the newsroom and it sets out a message to their audience of what journalists Both Lou and Nina see newsworthy stories simply as a way of getting professional recognition – be it in form of increased salary or higher TV ratings.

Lou is willing to orchestrate a police chase simply to get some impressive footage, even at the cost of several human lives. "We're professionals, he's a sale."
"I want something people can't turn away from."“ How much of this can we show?
"You mean legally?" "No, morally. Of course, legally.” (Nina, morning news director)

Spotlight:

(Positive) Cinematic representation of the newsroom and it sets out a message to their audience of what journalists do; meet with survivors, carefully listen to their stories, attend court sessions, analyze documents.

The journalists' sole focus is on telling an important story that would benefit the whole society – unveiling the sexual abuse of minors committed by Catholic priests. (spreads awareness).

Central thrust to the story; It took an outsider to see this system abusing these kids were wrong. "Twenty grand for molesting a child?" "If it takes a village to raise a child, it takes a village to abuse a child."

How important is the role of “Gender"

"If we cover this story, everyone will hear about it."

"I want to be that guy that owns the station, that owns the camera."

Nightcrawler

Stereotypically-Lou has masculine characteristics;
creepy, invasive, desensitized/ more drawn to graphic images of crime. Journalism (presented negatively) in media. He is getting his hands (lens) dirty.

Nina-stereotypically women are not positioned to be in high power. She is a efficient manager, who can run a large team and achieve great results(increasing the channel's ratings.) However, she had limited power/ which Lou tried to take advantage of.

Spotlight

Stereotypical roles; The journalist workforce is dominated by middle-aged white men. Most of those with higher power were men. The people abusing their power- lawyer, the church/ priest. However, there was also male, child abuse victims. A unique approach as often men's sexual abuse are not taken as seriously.
It took a young, unique/ 'outside' perspective to change the importance of the story.

Sacha- the only girl in the 'spotlight' investigative unit. She was looking after her nan and goes church with her nan(maternal). She's hardworking, represented as equally professional to her male colleagues. Apart from that, no overly emotional female stereotypes.

The obstacles faced by journalists and their relationship with power structures

Nightcrawler: obstacles

-Lou is under constant pressure to get new impressive footage.

Nightcrawler: power structure

-Lou was interrogated by the LAPD after being accused of concealing important information about the suspected murderers.

However, the LAPD was unable to prosecute Lou for his wrongdoings and he continuous to work for the channel.

Spotlight: obstacles

-Legal documents proving the priests' guilt were sealed by Catholic Church officials.
-Many victims did not want to speak to journalists about their traumatising experience.
-The Boston Globe faced criticism for failing to act on the matter earlier.
-competing for stories with The Boston Herald.

Spotlight: power structures

"Catholic community is going to have a very strong response to this." (Marty Baron, editor)

- Catholic Church has lots power in Boston (influential)
- 53% of the Boston Globe are Catholic

Themes of status

Nightcrawler:

- Main character Lou's status is immediately presented as a beginner as he is unsure of what he is doing and is often scolded for doing the wrong thing, as a man he starts off with less power but as he gains 'talent' he uses his masculinity to his advantage to get what he wants from Nina who is a women in power

- He often sexualises his encounters with her reinforcing male stereotypes, and even though she is in power as a women she is still disrespected

- As Lou also seems like an older man, age really plays into how he acts even though he is a beginner himself he looks down on Rick as a journalist because he is younger

Spotlight:

- Religion is a big factor as the priests are the criminals, it took years for the crimes to be uncovered showing the importance of religion and faith maybe being a big factor of the victims not being believed

- Both male and female journalists seem to be on the same level and treated the same

- Men are presented as more empathetic in this rather than cold hearted like the nightcrawler

- Age not of very focused on theme